

Religious Experience: Nature and Object

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE: THREE QUESTIONS

1. PHENOMENOLOGY

What is experienced? James: marks and fruits Otto: numinous Advaita: non-dual awareness

2. OBJECT

God, Holy or Sacred? Brahman or ultimate reality? Intentional encounter? No separate object in Advaita?

3. WARRANT

Is it veridical? Can testimony travel? Public-discourse criteria Diversity and naturalistic critique

Mediation does not automatically mean fabrication; neural correlation does not settle truth.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Religious Experience: Nature and Object - Learner-v2

Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 40

1. Which analytical sequence best prevents a category mistake while evaluating a religious experience?

- A. Describe its phenomenology, identify its claimed object, and then assess the warrant for believing that object real
B. Establish its object first, infer its phenomenology, and treat intensity as warrant
C. Test its moral fruits, infer its object, and omit the subject's report
D. Classify its ritual setting, assume its veridicality, and then describe its content

Answer: A.

Phenomenology asks what the experience is like; object asks what it purports to be of; warrant asks whether belief in that object is justified. An accurate description does not itself prove that the apparent object exists.

2. Which pair does James treat as the defining marks that entitle a state to be called mystical?

- A. Transiency and passivity
B. Ineffability and noetic quality
C. Conversion and saintliness
D. Unity and blessedness

Answer: B.

In *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, ineffability and noetic quality are the primary marks. Transiency and passivity are usual, less sharply marked accompaniments, not co-equal defining conditions.

3. What follows from James's grading of transiency and passivity?

- A. Every passive state is mystical even if it has no noetic quality
B. A mystical state must be both brief and involuntary
C. A stable, disciplined realisation may still be mystical if the defining marks are present
D. Indian *jñāna* cannot count as mystical because it aims at permanence

Answer: C.

Because transiency and passivity are usual rather than defining, stable Advaitic *jñāna* is not excluded merely for being cultivated and enduring. The classification turns principally on ineffability and noetic quality.

4. James's criticism of "medical materialism" is best understood as the claim that:

- A. religious experience has no physiological conditions
B. pathological experiences are invariably true
C. science is incapable of studying religious subjects
D. tracing an experience to a causal origin does not by itself settle its truth or value

Answer: D.

James rejects the genetic fallacy of discrediting a state solely through its neurological, temperamental or pathological origin. He does not deny causation; he denies that causal explanation alone is an epistemic refutation.

5. What is James's most defensible position on the authority of mystical states?

- A. They may authorise the experiencer but impose no unconditional authority on outsiders
B. They bind outsiders whenever the experiencer reports certainty
C. They have no authority even for the experiencer
D. They are public proofs once they produce good conduct

Answer: A.

James grants first-person authority while restricting transferability. Moral fruits may strengthen an authenticity judgement, but neither certainty nor transformation automatically creates publicly compelling proof.

6. Otto's *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* refers to:

- A. a moral inference from duty to God
B. the numinous as mysterious, overwhelming and attracting
C. the social separation of sacred objects from profane ones
D. non-dual recognition of Brahman as self

Answer: B.

Otto's numinous object evokes mystery, dread or overpowering creature-feeling, and fascination. Durkheim's sacred/profane classification and Advaita's identity-realisation are different accounts.

7. When Otto calls the numinous "non-rational," he most nearly means:

A. logically contradictory and therefore false B. produced by unconscious irrational impulses alone C. not exhaustively reducible to moral and conceptual judgement D. incapable of later ethical or theological interpretation

Answer: C.

"Non-rational" is not "irrational." Otto means that the numinous has a distinctive felt quality prior to full conceptual and moral schematisation, though rational and ethical ideas may subsequently interpret it.

8. Schleiermacher locates the essence of religion primarily in:

A. belief in miracles B. assent to ecclesiastical propositions C. fear of supernatural punishment D. the feeling of absolute dependence

Answer: D.

Schleiermacher's "feeling of absolute dependence" identifies a pre-theoretical consciousness of dependence upon the Infinite, contrasting religion with both mere doctrine and morality.

9. In Stace's typology, extrovertive mysticism is:

A. a unifying vision attained through the senses while multiplicity remains perceptible B. the exclusion of all sensory and conceptual content C. loving communion with a personal God alone D. an altered state necessarily caused by drugs

Answer: A.

Extrovertive mysticism perceives unity through the world of sensory multiplicity. Introvertive mysticism, by contrast, excludes sensory and conceptual content in favour of unitary consciousness.

10. Stace's introvertive mysticism is best characterised as:

A. a heightened perception of unity within nature B. non-spatial, non-temporal, contentless unitary consciousness C. ritual worship without petition D. a socially imposed sacred/profane distinction

Answer: B.

Introvertive experience withdraws from external and conceptual content, leaving pure undifferentiated unity. Stace treats it as the more complete mystical type.

11. Which claim is central to Stace's perennialist method?

A. Theistic mysticism is superior to monistic mysticism B. Traditions create wholly different experiences with no common features C. A common experiential core can be distinguished from divergent doctrinal interpretations D. Only Christian mystical reports possess noetic force

Answer: C.

Stace separates experience from interpretation: reported marks such as unity, objectivity, blessedness, sacredness, paradox and ineffability support a cross-cultural core, while doctrines differ.

12. Which classification belongs to R. C. Zaehner?

A. Healthy-mindedness, sick soul, conversion and saintliness B. Numinous, moral and rational consciousness C. Extrovertive and introvertive mysticism with one common core D. Nature, monistic and theistic mysticism

Answer: D.

Zaehner distinguishes nature mysticism, monistic mysticism and theistic mysticism. He denies Stace's flat common core and controversially ranks the theistic type highest.

13. Zaehner's pan-en-henic category denotes:

A. an "all-in-one" experience of unity with nature B. permanent isolation of *puruṣa* from *prakṛti* C. identity of the individual self with Brahman D. loving relation between creature and creator

Answer: A.

Pan-en-henic names Zaehner's nature mysticism, the sense of all things as one in nature. Monistic and theistic forms are separate categories in his scheme.

14. What is the strongest defensible treatment of Zaehner's ranking?

- A. Accept both the classification and the superiority of theism as neutral phenomenology
B. Retain the distinction among types while rejecting the confessionally loaded hierarchy
C. Reject the typology because every mystical report is identical
D. Replace it with James's four marks, which classify objects rather than states

Answer: B.

Zaehner insightfully preserves the logical difference between identity and relation, but his ranking of theistic mysticism is vulnerable to confessional bias. Classification need not entail hierarchy.

15. Steven Katz's constructivism holds that:

- A. mystical experience is always veridical but described differently
B. language affects only reports made long after an unmediated event
C. traditions, expectations and concepts shape the experience itself
D. contentless awareness proves all religions share one object

Answer: C.

Katz denies unmediated experience. A Jewish, Buddhist or Advaitic mystic does not merely label one neutral episode differently; the tradition helps constitute what is experienced.

16. Robert Forman's Pure Consciousness Event is intended mainly to challenge constructivism by claiming that:

- A. every experience contains detailed doctrinal imagery
B. only sensory perception can be concept-free
C. neural mediation guarantees objectivity
D. a contentless state leaves no experiential content for concepts to shape

Answer: D.

Forman presses the introvertive limit against Katz: if an episode is genuinely contentless, constructivist shaping appears to lack material on which to operate. Whether such complete contentlessness is possible remains disputed.

17. Alston's "M-perception" is:

- A. a non-sensory, perception-like awareness in which God appears to the subject
B. a deductive proof from mystical testimony to God
C. the moral transformation produced by worship
D. a neuroscientific measurement of religious states

Answer: A.

In *Perceiving God*, Alston uses a theory of appearing to argue that sensory content is not essential to perceptual structure. Some awareness of God may therefore be genuinely perception-like.

18. Why are doxastic practices important in Alston's argument?

- A. They eliminate all circularity in justifying belief
B. Beliefs arise within socially established practices with inputs, outputs and override procedures
C. They show that every religious tradition tracks the same object
D. They make mystical experiences repeatable laboratory observations

Answer: B.

Alston compares Christian mystical practice with sense perception and memory as socially established belief-forming practices. None is validated from nowhere; each uses internal support and correction.

19. Alston's conclusion is most accurately stated as:

- A. Christian mystical practice is infallible
B. every M-belief is *ultima facie* justified
C. engagement in an established mystical practice can be practically rational absent adequate defeaters
D. religious experience proves God more strongly than sense perception proves physical objects

Answer: C.

Alston defends practical rationality and *prima facie* justification, not demonstrated reliability or infallibility. His modest conclusion is often overstated.

20. What does Alston regard as the most serious pressure on his account?

A. Mystical experience has no phenomenological content B. Sense perception is never socially established C. Circular support occurs only in religion D. mutually incompatible religious doxastic practices may each appear internally rational

Answer: D.

Religious diversity threatens neutral adjudication: Christian, Advaitic, Buddhist and Islamic practices may support incompatible outputs. Alston's "sit tight" response acknowledges rather than dissolves the discomfort.

21. Swinburne's principle of credulity states, roughly, that:

A. if it seems to a subject that something is present, it probably is, unless there are defeaters B. all testimony is false unless independently verified C. religious seemings are justified only within a doxastic practice D. moral fruits deductively establish a transcendent cause

Answer: A.

Swinburne begins from the general trust normally given to appearances, subject to defeating conditions such as unreliability, conflicting evidence or alternative explanations. This differs from Alston's practice-based defence.

22. Which statement correctly handles neural correlations of mystical states?

A. Any neural cause proves the transcendent object unreal B. Causal mediation and epistemic defeat are distinct; a mechanism may carry either veridical or non-veridical experience C. Brain activity is irrelevant to any philosophical assessment D. A unique neural pattern would by itself prove God

Answer: B.

Ordinary perception also has neural mechanisms. To explain how an experience occurs is not yet to show that its apparent object is absent; further evidence is needed for an explaining-away defeater.

23. Hick's response to conflicting religious experiences is that:

A. only theistic reports are genuine B. contradictions disappear because doctrines have no cognitive content C. traditions may be culturally shaped responses to the one "Real" D. every experience is a direct perception of the same personal God

Answer: C.

Hick distinguishes the Real in itself from its diverse human apprehensions. The proposal accommodates plurality, though critics ask how an unknowable Real can ground determinate religious claims.

24. Which claim best distinguishes ineffability from unintelligibility?

A. An ineffable state cannot be remembered B. Ineffability means that no statement whatsoever may refer to the experience C. An unintelligible state is always veridical D. Ineffability limits exhaustive or adequate expression without making every partial description meaningless

Answer: D.

Mystics can report that an experience was unitary, peaceful or transformative while denying that words capture its quality fully. Otherwise the very classification "ineffable" could not enter discourse.

25. What is the central structure of Advaitic aparokṣānubhūti?

A. non-dual recognition of Brahman as one's own self rather than perception of an external object B. an emotional relation between two permanently distinct persons C. sensory vision of Brahman possessing finite attributes D. social classification of certain objects as sacred

Answer: A.

Advaita treats liberating knowledge as identity-recognition: the subject-object division is sublated. This differs logically from theistic mystical encounter, which retains relation.

26. Which use of anirvacanīya is technically correct in Advaita?

A. It names James's ineffability B. It characterises māyā or world-appearance as neither simply real nor unreal C. It is the standard name for Brahman's non-dual self-realisation D. It means that Brahman is irrational

Answer: B.

The common trap is to call Advaitic experience *anirvacaniya*. Advaita technically applies the term to māyā/world-appearance; Brahman-realisation is better described as non-objective and beyond exhaustive speech.

27. Why does stable Advaitic jñāna matter in comparison with James?

A. It shows no Indian state can be mystical B. It converts noetic quality into ordinary inference C. It shows that religious realisation may be established knowledge rather than a merely transient episode D. It proves passivity is James's sole defining mark

Answer: C.

Advaita emphasises stable removal of ignorance through knowledge. James's hierarchy permits this comparison because transiency is a usual accompaniment, not a necessary defining mark.

28. Radhakrishnan's "integral intuition" is best described as:

A. an arbitrary feeling exempt from reason B. sensory perception of a supernatural object C. assent to inherited dogma before experience D. disciplined awareness integrating cognition, feeling and will in apprehension of the spiritual Real

Answer: D.

Radhakrishnan gives direct *anubhava* priority over creeds and institutions, but his intuition is claimed as noetic, transformative and disciplined, not a mere hunch.

29. What is the essential act in prayer?

A. address or communication directed toward the divine B. public classification of an object as sacred C. ascription of supreme worth without any direction to an addressee D. non-dual elimination of every relation

Answer: A.

Prayer is fundamentally communicative-petition, confession, thanksgiving, praise or contemplation directed toward an addressee. This makes a responsive ultimate more central to prayer than to worship.

30. What is the essential act in worship?

A. requesting that a divine plan be changed B. acknowledging and enacting the supreme worth of the sacred C. reporting a private mystical episode D. proving that a deity exists

Answer: B.

Worship is homage or ascription of unsurpassable worth, usually embodied and communal. It can persist in Jain, Buddhist or Mīmāṃsā settings where answered petition is absent.

31. Why is adoration a useful boundary case?

A. It is neither prayer nor worship B. It is always a request for material benefit C. As address it is prayer, and as ascription of worth it is worship D. It occurs only in non-theistic religion

Answer: C.

Adoration demonstrates overlap without erasing distinction. Its communicative direction makes it prayer; its recognition of supreme value makes it worship.

32. Aquinas answers the apparent pointlessness of petitionary prayer by arguing that:

A. prayer gives God information previously unknown B. divine goodness changes whenever a request is sincere C. petition overrides an immutable providential order D. God may ordain that certain goods be obtained through prayer as a secondary cause

Answer: D.

Aquinas does not make prayer alter God. Prayer can be included within providence as the means through which an ordained outcome occurs.

33. Eleonore Stump's distinctive defence of petitionary prayer stresses:

A. the relational or friendship value of asking before receiving B. proof that every petition changes external events C. the logical mutability of a perfect God D. the superiority of petition over worship

Answer: A.

Stump argues that asking can protect the interpersonal structure of divine giving, especially where unsolicited benefaction by an overwhelmingly superior giver could compromise relationship. This does not prove outcome-dependence.

34. James Rachels' objection to worship is based on a tension between:

A. ineffability and public language B. unconditional obedience and moral autonomy C. non-dual awareness and sensory perception D. sacred time and profane space

Answer: B.

Rachels argues that worship appears to require abdication of final moral judgement. Replies distinguish recognition of perfect worth from blind obedience and deny that perfect goodness could command evil.

35. Why is Jain worship a decisive test case for the prayer/worship distinction?

A. Jainism regards every petition as infallibly answered B. Tirthaṅkaras create the world but refuse worship C. a *vītarāga* Tirthaṅkara may be worshipped despite being unable to respond to petitions D. Jain ritual denies that any reality has supreme value

Answer: C.

Jain *caitya-vandana* demonstrates worship without a responsive deity. The practice honours liberation and cultivates the worshipper's disposition rather than soliciting intervention.

36. In the Mīmāṃsā example, ritual efficacy is chiefly associated with:

A. an emotional vision of a personal God B. the moral fruits of conversion C. a Tirthaṅkara's gracious response D. *apūrva* generated by correct performance rather than a deity's discretionary grant

Answer: D.

Mīmāṃsā allows ritual orientation without a responsive divine agent. This is why worship or sacred observance has broader religious availability than petitionary prayer.

37. Which claim best captures the proper public-discourse verdict?

A. Religious experience can be publicly discussed and assessed for coherence and fruits without becoming publicly demonstrated B. Ineffability prevents any meaningful public description C. Private certainty automatically transfers to all rational observers D. Public discussion is possible only after proving the transcendent object

Answer: A.

First-person reports, typologies, practices and effects are discussable. What remains non-transferable is the full evidential force that the episode has for the subject.

38. Habermas's translation proviso is relevant because it permits:

A. the state to enforce private revelation without reasons B. religious expression in the informal public sphere while requiring generally accessible reasons for formal state decisions C. only secular citizens to participate in public debate D. mystical certainty to replace constitutional argument

Answer: B.

The distinction supplies a graded account of publicity: religious language need not be excluded from civic life, yet coercive institutions require reasons accessible beyond one faith community.

39. Which distinction between Otto and Durkheim is correct?

A. Both define the sacred only as a personal God B. Otto gives a social classification, whereas Durkheim describes creature-feeling C. Otto's holy is a phenomenological quality; Durkheim's sacred is defined relationally against the profane D. Both regard non-theistic religion as impossible

Answer: C.

Otto focuses on the numinous mode of appearance; Durkheim focuses on social separation and communal practice. Their terms overlap in ordinary use but perform different explanatory jobs.

40. What is the best way to prevent “the sacred” from becoming so broad that any collectively valued object counts as religious?

A. Restrict it to objects producing fear B. Require belief in a creator C. Count only objects named in scriptures D. add a soteriological relation to the diagnosis and overcoming of the fundamental human predicament

Answer: D.

A soteriological condition excludes merely patriotic or recreational objects while preserving non-theistic religious ultimates such as nirvāṇa, Dharma and liberation.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

41. A candidate writes, “James gives four equally necessary marks of every religious experience.” Which correction is best?

A. The four concern mystical states; ineffability and noetic quality are defining, while transiency and passivity are usual accompaniments B. The four concern worship; only passivity is defining C. The four concern revelation; all are optional D. James rejects every attempt to classify experience

Answer: A.

This corrects both errors: James is classifying mystical states rather than all religion, and he explicitly grades the marks. Treating all four as equally necessary misrepresents him and wrongly excludes stable, cultivated realisation.

42. Which reformulation best corrects the claim “If a mystical experience is ineffable, it is meaningless”?

A. Ineffability guarantees that every metaphysical interpretation is true B. Ineffability denies exhaustive expression, not all intelligible reference, comparison or report C. Ineffability applies only to bodily sensations D. Ineffability and logical contradiction are identical

Answer: B.

An experience may resist adequate transmission while remaining partially describable as unitary, peaceful, noetic or transformative. The concept limits language; it does not abolish language.

43. What is the correct response to “If tradition mediates experience, tradition must fabricate it”?

A. All mediated experiences are false B. Religious experience is uniquely free from concepts C. Mediation shapes access and interpretation but does not by itself establish that no independent object is disclosed D. Fabrication is guaranteed whenever practices precede an experience

Answer: C.

Katz shows that mediation is epistemically important, but the move from “concept-laden” to “invented” is invalid. Ordinary perception is also mediated; objectivity depends on constraints, correction and defeaters.

44. Which correction best addresses the equation of Otto’s “holy” with Durkheim’s “sacred”?

A. Both terms refer exclusively to moral goodness B. Both are names for Advaita’s Brahman C. Otto and Durkheim offer the same theory in different languages D. Otto analyses a numinous phenomenological quality, whereas Durkheim analyses a social separation from the profane

Answer: D.

Their concepts can overlap in religious life but answer different questions. Otto asks how the object appears; Durkheim asks how sacred classification and community function.

45. Which statement correctly distinguishes prayer from worship?

A. Prayer is address and normally presupposes a responsive addressee; worship is ascription of supreme worth and can occur without answered petition B. Prayer is always private, whereas worship is always public C. Prayer is necessarily petition, whereas worship excludes praise D. Non-theistic traditions can have neither prayer nor worship

Answer: A.

Form and location vary, so private/public is not the essence. Adoration overlaps both practices, but Jain and Mīmāṃsā cases show that worship survives without a deity who answers requests.

46. Why is it misleading to say that Advaita is an experience “of Brahman” in exactly the same sense that Otto describes experience “of the Holy”?

A. Advaita denies consciousness B. Advaita’s highest realisation sublates subject-object duality, whereas Otto retains intentional encounter with the wholly other C. Otto teaches identity of ātman and Brahman D. Both accounts reduce religion to social ritual

Answer: B.

The logical forms differ: Advaita is identity-recognition, while Otto’s numinous experience has an experiencer directed toward an other. “Object” must therefore be used carefully.

47. Which inference illegitimately moves from phenomenology to warrant?

A. “The report contains a sense of unity; therefore unity belongs to its phenomenology.” B. “The subject felt passive; therefore the state resembles James’s usual mystical marks.” C. “The experience felt absolutely real; therefore its transcendent object certainly exists.” D. “The report is culturally shaped; therefore its interpretation requires analysis.”

Answer: C.

A sense of objectivity is itself phenomenological evidence, not proof that the apparent object exists. Veridicality requires separate assessment of reliability, defeaters and competing explanations.

48. Which comparison between Swinburne and Alston is accurate?

A. Both offer deductive proofs from mystical reports B. Alston formulates the principle of credulity, while Swinburne analyses doxastic practices C. Both conclude that religious diversity is irrelevant D. Swinburne starts from a general presumption in favour of seemings; Alston defends rational engagement in socially established belief-forming practices

Answer: D.

Swinburne’s argument is appearance-based and defeasible; Alston’s is practice-based and culminates in practical rationality and *prima facie* justification. Neither yields infallibility.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 8 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

These are independent practice models prepared from the verified question ledger; they are not official UPSC answers or marking keys.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: The terms ‘Sacred’ and ‘Holy’ have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Explain why “sacred” and “holy” can cover religion generally; distinguish their major meanings; then give a graded answer on whether God may be religion’s object without making God its universally necessary object.

Model solution: The “object of religion” is that ultimate reality, power, state or value toward which religious consciousness and practice are directed. My thesis is graded: God can certainly be the object of religion in theistic traditions, but cannot define the object of religion generically. “Sacred” is the broader comparative category; God is the theistic paradigm within it.

The terms “holy” and “sacred” are not exact synonyms. In *The Idea of the Holy*, Rudolf Otto treats the Holy, prior to its moral schematisation, as the **numinous**—the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. Its object is experienced as mysterious and “wholly other,” producing creature-feeling, dread and fascination. Otto’s account is phenomenological: it describes how the object appears. Émile Durkheim, by contrast, defines the sacred socially through its separation from the profane and the prohibitions and communal practices surrounding it. Mircea Eliade adds the idea of **hierophany**: the sacred manifests and structures religious space, time and orientation. Thus Otto’s holy is a distinctive quality disclosed in experience, whereas Durkheim’s sacred is a social classification. Collapsing them obscures the difference between phenomenology and function.

These generic terms are useful because religion is wider than theism. Buddhism relates life to Dharma, nirvāṇa and awakening without a creator-God. Jainism venerates the liberated Tīrthaṅkara and *siddha*, not a world-creating deity. Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as *apauruṣeya* and ritual efficacy through *apūrva*, without requiring a divine author or grantor. Indian categories such as *pavitra*, *maṅgala*, *tīrtha* and *kṣetra* also show that purity, auspiciousness, sacred space and soteriological power-not only Otto's awe-organise religious life.

Nevertheless, God can be the object of religion. In classical theism, Judaism, Islam, Christianity, Viśiṣṭādvaita and many bhakti traditions, prayer, worship and revelation are intentionally directed toward a personal divine reality. God is not merely one sacred item among others but the source and measure of holiness: persons, texts and places are holy through relation to God. "Object" here must not imply an ordinary finite object passively inspected. It means the intentional pole of faith, worship and encounter-an inexhaustible subject who addresses the worshipper.

Two objections qualify this account. First, "sacred" may become so broad that flags, nations or celebrities count as religious objects. The reply is to add a **soteriological condition**: the religiously sacred is related to the diagnosis and overcoming of the fundamental human predicament. Second, a theist may object that calling God a "species" of the sacred subordinates God to a higher genus. The reply is conceptual, not ontological: comparative philosophy needs a category covering diverse religions; it does not deny the theist's claim that God is ontologically ultimate.

Finally, identifying a claimed object must be separated from establishing its reality. Otto may accurately describe numinous intentionality without proving a numinous being, just as Durkheim may explain sacred classification without exhausting its possible transcendent reference. The phenomenology of an object, the specification of that object and the warrant for believing it exists are distinct questions.

An Indian-Western comparison further qualifies the word "object." In theistic mysticism and prayer, God is encountered through an I-Thou relation. Radhakrishnan and Advaita, however, interpret the highest realisation non-dually: Brahman is not confronted as an Other but realised as the depth of self. Buddhism may regard even substantial "object" language as misleading. Hence comparative philosophy must allow object to mean the ultimate intentional or soteriological pole, not invariably a separately existing personal being.

Therefore, one can have God as the object of religion, decisively so within theism. But God cannot serve as religion's universal defining object without excluding non-theistic religions by stipulation. The best verdict is: **the sacred is the comparative genus; God is theism's paradigm instance and, for the believer, the source of all holiness.**

Why this earns marks: Directly answers the "do you agree" clause; distinguishes Otto, Durkheim and Eliade; supplies Indian non-theistic counter-cases; separates object from warrant; handles two objections; ends with a graded verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse? Analyse.

Demand decoding: Give a degree, not a yes/no. Separate public description and assessment from public proof, identify limits created by privacy and ineffability, and state precisely what remains publicly discussable.

Model solution: Religious experience can enter public discourse extensively as **reported data, interpreted meaning and disciplined practice**, but only limitedly as publicly compelling evidence for its transcendent object. The crucial distinction is between discussing an experience, testing the authenticity of its report and proving what the experience claims to disclose.

The case against public discourse begins with first-person privacy. William James calls mystical states ineffable and grants them authority primarily for the experiencer, not for outsiders. Their felt certainty is not transferable. Unlike ordinary perception, there may be no neutral procedure by which observers reproduce the episode and correct misidentification. Wittgenstein's private-language considerations deepen the worry: a wholly private criterion cannot sustain a stable distinction between seeming right and being right. In political settings, Rawlsian public reason also bars private revelation from functioning as a coercive reason binding citizens who do not share it.

Yet privacy does not entail silence. First, **phenomenological descriptions** are public: James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner constructed comparative classifications from first-person testimony. Even saying that an experience is ineffable conveys its limits and effects; ineffability means resistance to exhaustive expression, not unintelligibility. Second, reports can be tested for internal coherence, consistency with other beliefs and absence of obvious pathology or manipulation. Third, traditions maintain public rules of discernment-spiritual direction, doctrinal checks and the

guru's examination of a disciple. Fourth, James's test by "fruits" concerns observable moral integration and conduct, though good effects establish authenticity more readily than metaphysical truth.

The Indian contribution strengthens the intersubjective case. *Yoga*, *dhyaṇa* and *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* are presented as disciplined procedures with stated preconditions and expected transformations. This is not laboratory replication, because training and commitment shape access; nevertheless, it resembles expert perception, which also requires acquired capacities. William Alston's account of socially established doxastic practices similarly makes religious experience a legitimate subject of public argument about inputs, outputs and override procedures, while not proving the practice reliable from a neutral standpoint.

The strongest objection remains that these criteria test sincerity, coherence and authenticity, not the existence of God or Brahman. That objection should be conceded. Habermas offers an appropriate political analogue: religious claims may enter the informal public sphere in their own language, but must be translated into generally accessible reasons before formal state decisions.

Thus religious experience is publicly discussable in description, comparison, interpretation, moral consequences and disciplined modes of cultivation. Its first-person evidential force, however, cannot be transferred intact. The analytically defensible verdict is: **publicly assessable and privately probative, but not publicly demonstrative.**

Why this earns marks: Obeys "how far"; distinguishes discourse, authenticity and truth; uses James, Wittgenstein, Alston and Indian disciplines; concedes the decisive limitation; gives a precise graded conclusion.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religion.

Demand decoding: Complete both tasks: establish the essential differentia between prayer and worship, including overlap and non-theistic cases, and then explain the distinct function of each in religious life.

Model solution: Prayer and worship overlap, especially in adoration, but they are not synonyms. **Prayer is address or communication directed toward the divine; worship is the acknowledgement and enactment of supreme worth.** Prayer normally presupposes an addressee capable of hearing; worship requires only a reality regarded as ultimately valuable.

Prayer may be verbal or silent, spontaneous or prescribed, private or congregational. Its classical forms are summarised by ACTS: adoration, confession, thanksgiving and supplication; intercession and contemplative prayer may be added. Worship is characteristically embodied, ritual and communal-prostration, liturgy, offering, praise and sacred observance. Adoration is the intersection: as address it is prayer; as attribution of unsurpassable worth it is worship. Petition, however, is prayer without necessarily being the core of worship.

Wordless contemplation is a limit case: communicative directedness can remain even when articulated requests disappear, so silence alone does not convert prayer into worship.

This distinction exposes different philosophical problems. Petitionary prayer appears redundant if God is omniscient, perfectly good and immutable: God already knows the need, wills the best and cannot be altered. Aquinas replies that prayer does not change the divine will; God may ordain that certain goods be obtained **through** prayer, making it a secondary cause. Eleonore Stump further argues that asking has relational value: it preserves a friendship-like structure between giver and recipient. The reply explains prayer's place even if it does not prove that events causally depend on petitions.

Worship faces James Rachels' autonomy objection: unconditional obedience seems incompatible with responsible moral agency. But worship need not mean surrendering moral judgement. It can be recognition of perfect worth, gratitude and self-transformation; obedience to a perfectly good being would not license evil.

Indian traditions show why worship is broader than prayer. Jain *caitya-vandana* honours a *vīṭarāga* Tīrthaṅkara who neither intervenes nor answers petitions. Mīmāṃsā locates ritual efficacy in *apūrva*, not a granting deity. Buddhist *pūjā* can be commemorative and dispositional. Advaita treats *upāsana* of saṁgha Brahman as spiritually effective at the *vyāvahārika* level, though ultimately transcended in non-dual knowledge. Hence worship survives where petitionary address is absent.

Prayer is religion's **relational organ**: it gives practical form to dependence, trust, confession and hope. Worship is its **evaluative and communal organ**: it marks the sacred as ultimate, forms a community and disciplines desire through embodied practice. A religion may survive without petition; it cannot survive without worship in the broad sense of

orienting life toward what is held supremely valuable. Therefore worship is more nearly universal, while prayer expresses the specifically dialogical dimension of religion.

Why this earns marks: Gives a sharp essential distinction, identifies overlap, addresses petition and autonomy, uses Aquinas, Stump and Rachels, adds decisive Indian non-theistic cases, and determines each practice's religious function.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the concept of religious experience in the light of Vedāntic tradition.

Demand decoding: Use Vedānta's own categories and acknowledge internal plurality. Explain immediate realisation, its preparation, nature and object, then distinguish Advaitic identity from qualified-non-dual and dualistic encounter.

Model solution: In Vedānta, religious experience is not merely an intense feeling but the culmination of a disciplined search for liberating knowledge of the relation among self, world and Brahman. Its common aspiration is **direct realisation-anubhava** or *aparokṣānubhūti*-yet Vedāntic schools differ on whether this realisation is identity with Brahman or communion with a distinct Lord.

The Upaniṣadic background gives priority to transformative knowledge. Scripture (*śruti*) discloses what sense perception cannot, reason removes contradiction, and spiritual discipline makes the aspirant fit for realisation. Thus experience is not an isolated psychological episode. It arises through ethical preparation, hearing (*śravaṇa*), reflection (*manana*), meditation (*nididhyāsana*), devotion or divine grace, according to the school concerned.

For Śaṅkara's Advaita, the highest experience is the non-objective recognition that ātman is Brahman, articulated by *aham brahmāsmi*. Subject-object duality belongs to ignorance; Brahman cannot be confronted as an external object because it is self-luminous consciousness presupposed by every act of knowing. The realisation is non-dual, self-certifying and liberating, and stable *jñāna* is more important than a passing ecstasy. It is beyond exhaustive objectifying language, but not unintelligible. Nor should it be called *anirvacanīya*: technically, that term characterises māyā or world-appearance, not Brahman-realisation.

Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita rejects the erasure of difference. Brahman is personal, with selves and world as real modes dependent upon God. Religious fulfilment therefore takes the form of loving knowledge, devotion and communion, not the disappearance of the worshipper. Madhva's Dvaita makes the distinction stronger: God and soul remain eternally different, and saving experience is a grace-enabled relation to Viṣṇu. Vedānta consequently includes both **identity-recognition** and **intentional encounter**.

The epistemic status also varies accordingly. Advaita calls realisation self-certifying because self-luminous consciousness is not established through a second cognition. Devotional schools place greater weight on scripture, grace and the transformed relation of dependence. In every case, however, the experience is soteriological: it is assessed by whether it removes ignorance, egoism and bondage, not simply by its emotional intensity. This distinguishes Vedāntic *anubhava* from an unregulated private impression.

An objection follows: if these accounts have incompatible structures, "Vedāntic experience" may be only doctrinal interpretation imposed upon ambiguous states. The reply is not to manufacture a flat common core. Rather, mediation need not equal fabrication: each school offers a disciplined practice, conceptual grammar and tests of transformation through which experience is identified. Still, these internal criteria do not by themselves prove the metaphysical object to outsiders.

Therefore Vedāntic religious experience is best understood as tradition-guided, transformative and soteriological directness to the Real. Its distinctive philosophical range runs from Advaita's non-dual self-recognition to the devotional schools' enduring relation with a personal Brahman.

Why this earns marks: Uses internal Vedāntic vocabulary; covers preparation and liberation; distinguishes Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja and Madhva; preserves identity-versus-relation; handles the mediation objection without flattening differences.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James.

Demand decoding: Present James's empirical-pragmatic method, correctly grade the marks of mystical states, and cover the wider varieties of personal religion rather than reducing the answer to a flat four-item list.

Model solution: In *The Varieties of Religious Experience*, William James studies religion empirically through first-person documents and pragmatically through its effects on life. Religious experience is primarily personal before it becomes institutional, and its value cannot be dismissed merely by tracing a neurological or pathological origin. James calls such dismissal “medical materialism”: causal origin alone does not decide truth or worth.

James’s celebrated four marks apply specifically to **mystical states**, not to all religious experience, and they are not equal. **Ineffability** and **noetic quality** are the two defining marks. The experience cannot be adequately conveyed to one who has not undergone it, yet it presents itself as insight into depths unavailable to discursive intellect. Ineffability is therefore not unintelligibility, and noetic force is felt authority rather than independently demonstrated knowledge.

Transiency and **passivity** are usual but less sharply marked accompaniments. Mystical states are commonly brief; once they begin, the subject feels grasped by a superior power, though voluntary practices may prepare their onset.

James’s “variety” is broader than mysticism. He contrasts healthy-minded religion, which affirms goodness and harmony, with the religion of the “sick soul,” acutely conscious of evil, guilt and dividedness. The divided self seeks unification, often through conversion. Saintliness names the durable moral and affective fruits of religious transformation. Mysticism represents the direct experiential pole in which the self feels connected with a wider “MORE,” sometimes mediated through the subconscious. James accordingly judges religious life by enduring fruits rather than unusual intensity alone.

These forms are not a rigid hierarchy. James’s case-based method asks how temperaments confront evil, attain unification and produce a workable religious life. It preserves plurality within personal religion instead of deriving every case from one creed.

His great strength is methodological openness: he takes testimony seriously without allowing private conviction to coerce outsiders. Mystical experience may rationally authorise the experiencer, but it establishes no unconditional authority over others. This is also the limit of his epistemology. Good fruits may authenticate transformation but cannot prove that the “MORE” exists; culturally conflicting experiences intensify the problem.

An Indian comparison clarifies James’s own grading. Advaitic *jñāna* can be stable and established rather than transient, and the culmination of disciplined inquiry rather than sheer passivity. It can still qualify as mystical because James makes ineffability and noetic quality defining, while transiency and passivity are only usual.

Thus James offers a rich phenomenology and psychology of personal religion-healthy-mindedness, sick soul, conversion, saintliness and mysticism-while keeping its metaphysical object open. His account is strongest as empirical classification and pragmatic assessment, not as a proof of veridicality.

Why this earns marks: Correctly grades James’s marks; covers method, “medical materialism,” “MORE,” conversion and saintliness; distinguishes personal authority from public proof; uses Indian comparison analytically.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Examine the relation between mystical experience and revelation and expound their significance in the religious life.

Demand decoding: Define both terms, analyse several possible relations without identifying them, and then separately explain what each contributes to religious life, including criteria that limit private revelation.

Model solution: Mystical experience is an immediate or apparently immediate awareness of, union with or identity in ultimate reality. Revelation is disclosure of religious truth or divine reality. They may converge, but they are not identical: mystical experience concerns a mode of consciousness, while revelation concerns disclosure and its claimed authority.

Their relation can take three forms. First, mystical experience may be a **vehicle of non-propositional revelation**: God or the Real is disclosed through presence rather than sentences. Otto’s numinous encounter and theistic mysticism exemplify disclosure as experienced relation. Second, propositions may arise as interpretations of the experience; the experience is primary, while doctrines articulate what was encountered. William James’s noetic quality explains why mystics regard their states as revelatory, but James restricts their authority to the subject. Third, prior revelation can discipline experience. A scriptural and ritual tradition supplies categories, practices and criteria through which an episode is cultivated and identified.

The relation differs in Indian traditions. In Advaita, *śruti* does not reveal Brahman as an external object. It removes ignorance and prepares *aparokṣānubhūti*, the recognition that ātman is Brahman. Here revelation and mystical

realisation are complementary: textual testimony points, reason clarifies, and non-dual awareness fulfils the teaching. Theistic Vedānta, by contrast, can interpret mystical experience as grace-enabled communion with a personal God, preserving knower-known relation.

Their significance in religious life is substantial. Revelation supplies orientation, a shared narrative and normative content; mystical experience vivifies these rather than leaving them as second-hand belief. It can deepen prayer and worship, produce conversion, unify the divided self and renew institutions through prophetic or saintly witness. Its moral fruits also provide public evidence of transformation, even when its object remains disputed.

Conversely, revelation without lived appropriation can harden into external authority, while mysticism without revelatory or rational regulation can become incommunicable or self-authorising. Their conjunction gives religious life both experiential depth and accountable form.

The strongest objection is epistemic: private experiences generate conflicting revelations and can legitimate fanaticism. Steven Katz's constructivism adds that traditions may shape the experience itself, not merely its later description. The reply must be discriminating, not credulous. Mediation does not automatically mean fabrication, since ordinary perception is concept-laden too; nevertheless, claims require tests of coherence, moral fruits, tradition-sensitive discernment and compatibility with responsible reason. Such tests establish authenticity more readily than metaphysical truth.

Therefore mystical experience may mediate and personally confirm revelation, while revelation may interpret and regulate mystical life. Their significance lies in joining lived transformation to inherited meaning. But no private mystical claim should acquire unconditional public or moral authority merely because it feels self-certifying.

Why this earns marks: Defines both poles; gives three relations; integrates James, Otto, Katz and Advaita; explains religious significance separately; confronts conflict and fanaticism; ends with a qualified assessment.

PYQ 7 - 2024, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the main features of religious experience according to Advaita Vedānta.

Demand decoding: Enumerate Advaita's distinctive features in tradition-specific terms, explain how its "object" differs from an intentional object, and assess the content and criterion objection.

Model solution: For Advaita Vedānta, the highest religious experience is not a subject's encounter with an external God but the immediate recognition of non-dual reality: ātman is Brahman. Its central term is *aparokṣānubhūti*, direct realisation, and its soteriological result is the destruction of ignorance and liberation.

First, the experience is **non-dual**. Ordinary cognition divides knower, knowing and known; Advaita regards this division as conditioned by *avidyā*. In liberating knowledge the supposed separation is sublated. *Aham brahmāsmi* therefore expresses identity, not proximity or emotional union between two already constituted beings.

Second, it is **self-luminous and self-certifying**. Consciousness is not known through another act, since every act of knowing presupposes it. Brahman, as the reality of consciousness, cannot be converted into an object without reproducing the duality to be overcome. The "object" of experience is thus realised as one's own Self; strictly, the object-pole disappears.

Third, the realisation is beyond exhaustive objectifying speech. Upaniṣadic negation such as *neti neti* removes limiting predicates, while mahāvākyas disclose identity. This is not meaninglessness. Nor is the realisation technically *anirvacanīya*: in Advaita that term characterises māyā or world-appearance as neither simply real nor unreal. Brahman is real; its non-objectifiability is better expressed through the limits of speech.

Fourth, the experience is transformative and blissful (*ānanda*), terminating bondage rooted in misidentification. Fifth, it is not merely a brief altered state. *Śravaṇa*, *manana* and *nididhyāsana* culminate in stable *jñāna*. James's transiency and passivity are therefore, at most, usual marks of many mystical episodes, not requirements Advaita must satisfy.

Sixth, Advaita distinguishes the empirical and ultimate standpoints. Devotion and *upāsana* directed toward saguṇa Brahman remain valid and purificatory at the *vyāvahārika* level; non-dual knowledge discloses nirguṇa Brahman at the *pāramārthika* level. They are not simply discarded as meaningless. This graded structure explains how intentional religious practice can prepare for a realisation in which intentional duality is finally overcome.

The strongest objection is that a contentless, non-dual state cannot justify the determinate judgement "I am Brahman"; perhaps doctrine constructs the interpretation. Advaita replies that *śruti* functions as a *pramāṇa* that removes

ignorance rather than producing a new object. Like the tenth-man instruction, it discloses an already present fact; disciplined reflection blocks arbitrary interpretation. Still, this establishes tradition-internal intelligibility more readily than public proof.

Hence Advaitic religious experience is immediate, non-dual, self-luminous, non-objective, liberating and stabilised as knowledge. Its philosophical distinctiveness lies in **identity-recognition**, unlike Otto's encounter with the wholly other or theistic mysticism's relation to a personal God.

Why this earns marks: Lists and explains the main features; avoids the *anirvacanīya* error; uses mahāvākya and method; contrasts identity with encounter; presents the strongest objection and a bounded reply.

PYQ 8 - 2025, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Evaluate the nature and object of Religious Experience as explained by Radhakrishnan in 'The Hindu View of Life'.

Demand decoding: Remain faithful to the named work; separately identify the nature and object of experience; explain the priority of experience over dogma and ritual; then evaluate universality, mediation and veridicality with a graded verdict.

Model solution: In *The Hindu View of Life*, S. Radhakrishnan presents religion fundamentally as realised spiritual life rather than assent to a closed creed. My thesis is that his account powerfully explains the immediacy, integrality and transformative force of religious experience, but its movement from experiential certainty to a universal spiritual object remains philosophically contestable.

The **nature** of religious experience is direct *anubhava*: an immediate, intuitive apprehension of reality, not a conclusion mechanically inferred from sense-data or discursive reasoning. Radhakrishnan's "intuition" is not a hunch or anti-intellectual feeling. It is an **integral awareness** in which cognition, feeling and will are unified. Discursive reason analyses and divides; spiritual intuition apprehends wholes and transforms the person. It is therefore noetic as well as affective, and its authenticity appears in a reorientation of conduct and character.

The experience is also self-certifying for the subject. Its immediacy resembles the Advaitic claim that consciousness is self-revealing. Yet Radhakrishnan does not treat religious life as a licence for arbitrary private impressions. Preparation, ethical purification, contemplation and the inherited wisdom of the tradition discipline intuition. Experience is primary, but reason remains necessary to interpret it, compare claims and prevent fanaticism.

Its **object** is the spiritual Real or Spirit that is also the depth of the self. Religious experience overcomes the ordinary separation of subject and object; the ultimate is not encountered as one finite item among others. In this Advaitically inflected account, one does not merely perceive God from outside but participates in or realises a deeper unity of self and reality. Nevertheless, Radhakrishnan allows personal symbols and devotional forms a genuine place in finite religious life. The impersonal and personal are not simply competing deities; personal conceptions can mediate an ultimate reality exceeding complete conceptual determination.

This priority of experience explains his view of Hinduism as non-dogmatic and dynamically receptive. Creeds, rituals, myths and institutions are secondary formulations of realised spiritual depth. Their plurality need not prove that the Real is plural; it may show that one depth is interpreted through different histories and temperaments. His view thus supports inter-religious hospitality and gives Indian *anubhava* parity with Western appeals to revelation or mystical encounter.

Several comparisons sharpen the account. Like James, Radhakrishnan treats personal experience and transformative fruits as more fundamental than institution, but he makes a stronger metaphysical claim about spiritual reality. Unlike Otto's intentional encounter with the numinous "wholly other," his highest experience tends toward non-dual integration. Like Advaita, he distinguishes non-objective realisation from ordinary perception, though his comparative philosophy emphasises universality across traditions.

Three objections arise. First, self-certifying certainty for the subject is not public proof of the object. Swinburne's principle of credulity may grant prima facie warrant absent defeaters, and Alston may defend rational participation in an established doxastic practice, but neither establishes Radhakrishnan's Spirit conclusively. Second, religious diversity may resist reduction to one experiential core: theistic communion, Buddhist emptiness and Advaitic identity differ logically, not merely verbally. Radhakrishnan risks assimilating them to Advaita. A modest reply is to claim family resemblance and analogous transformation rather than identical content. Third, constructivists argue that concepts

and practices shape experience itself. The proper answer is that **mediation is not necessarily fabrication**; all perception is interpreted. Yet this reply also requires abandoning the claim of a wholly tradition-free intuition.

Radhakrishnan is therefore strongest as a phenomenology and philosophy of lived religion: he explains why spiritual realisation precedes, animates and criticises dogma. He is less decisive as an epistemologist, because intensity, self-certification and good fruits do not by themselves prove a common spiritual object. The graded verdict is that his account gives religious experience *prima facie* personal authority and profound comparative value, while the universality and veridicality of its object remain defensible hypotheses rather than demonstrated conclusions.

Why this earns marks: Anchors the answer in *The Hindu View of Life*; separates nature from object; explains integral intuition and secondary dogma; compares James, Otto and Advaita; tests universality, constructivism and warrant; delivers an evaluative verdict.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS

The following are original, independently prepared practice questions and model answers, not UPSC PYQs or official solutions.

ORIGINAL 1 - 10 marks

Question: Does the ineffability of religious experience prevent it from yielding knowledge? Examine.

Model solution: Ineffability limits the communication and doctrinal use of religious experience, but it does not automatically prevent every kind of knowledge. The issue turns on distinguishing **knowledge by acquaintance**, partial propositional articulation and publicly demonstrable knowledge.

William James identifies ineffability and noetic quality as the defining marks of mystical states. The mystic cannot adequately transfer the quality of the state to a non-participant, yet experiences it as insight into a deeper reality. This is not self-contradictory. Taste and pain also exceed complete description while supporting correct first-person judgements. Mystics can additionally make limited claims-unity, peace, dependence or non-duality-without claiming exhaustive capture.

Religious language may therefore function negatively, analogically or symbolically: it can exclude false literal pictures and direct attention without reproducing the experience. Such disciplined partial speech is weaker than a complete definition but stronger than silence.

However, noetic feeling is not sufficient warrant. If an experience is wholly ineffable, determinate inferences such as “a personal creator exists” may outrun its content. Conflicting reports of God, Brahman and emptiness strengthen this objection. Good moral fruits establish transformation more readily than the metaphysical truth of the interpretation.

A qualified reply distinguishes the experience from its interpretation. Negative and analogical language may communicate boundaries; traditions can test coherence, preparation and fruits. Advaita similarly treats Brahman as non-objectifiable but uses *śruti* and reason to remove error. Still, these resources give tradition-internal articulation, not coercive public proof.

Therefore ineffability does not reduce religious experience to unintelligibility. It may yield immediate or acquaintance-like knowledge and defeasible personal warrant, but it restricts exhaustive description and weakens the move to detailed, universally binding doctrine.

Why this earns marks: Direct thesis; James correctly graded; acquaintance/proposition/public-proof distinction; diversity objection; Advaita comparison; qualified verdict.

ORIGINAL 2 - 10 marks

Question: Compare Otto's numinous encounter with Advaita's non-dual awareness as two accounts of religious experience.

Model solution: Otto and Advaita both resist reducing religion to discursive belief, but their experiences have fundamentally different logical structures: Otto describes an **intentional encounter with an Other**, whereas Advaita describes **identity-recognition in which otherness is sublated**.

In *The Idea of the Holy*, Otto calls the object the numinous, experienced as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. The subject feels creaturely, overwhelmed and yet attracted before the “wholly other.” “Non-rational” means irreducible to ordinary moral and conceptual predicates, not irrational. The subject and numinous object remain distinct.

Advaita's *aparokṣānubhūti* is direct recognition that ātman is Brahman. Since self-luminous consciousness presupposes every objectifying cognition, Brahman cannot be one external item perceived by a subject. *Aham brahmāsmi* expresses non-dual identity. The realisation is liberating and stabilised as *jñāna*, not necessarily the transient passivity often found in mystical episodes.

Both accounts stress immediacy, non-exhaustive language and transformation. Yet assimilating them into a single "mystical feeling" erases the difference between relation and identity. The strongest objection to Otto is that awe may be psychologically explained without a numinous object; the strongest objection to Advaita is that a contentless state cannot justify the specific judgement of Brahman-identity. Otto can reply that causal explanation does not exhaust intentional structure; Advaita replies that *śruti* removes ignorance rather than constructing an object.

Their soteriological orientations also differ. Otto's analysis begins from a creature's response to holiness and awaits ethical-theological schematisation; Advaita places the experience within a path whose cognitive culmination removes *avidyā*. The former centres reverent encounter, the latter liberating knowledge.

Thus the accounts are comparable as non-discursive phenomenologies, but not interchangeable. Otto preserves encounter; Advaita culminates in non-dual recognition.

Why this earns marks: Clear comparator; precise doctrines; non-rational clarified; identity-versus-relation made decisive; matched objections and replies; concise verdict.

ORIGINAL 3 - 15 marks

Question: "The moral fruits of a religious experience authenticate the subject but do not verify the transcendent object." Critically discuss.

Model solution: The proposition is substantially correct: moral fruits are powerful evidence that an experience has reorganised a life and may count against pathology or self-deception, but they do not by themselves verify God, Brahman or another transcendent object.

William James evaluates religion pragmatically "by its fruits," examining conversion, saintliness, integration of the divided self and durable conduct rather than extraordinary intensity. This criterion has three strengths. First, effects are publicly observable even when the original state is private. Second, enduring compassion, courage and freedom from ego provide evidence that the report is not a fleeting mood. Third, fruits allow comparison across traditions without requiring prior agreement about theology. Indian traditions similarly test realisation through freedom from attachment, ethical discipline and transformed conduct; the guru does not accept every ecstasy as liberating knowledge.

Nevertheless, beneficial consequences do not entail metaphysical truth. A false belief can inspire sacrifice, while a veridical perception can produce no moral improvement. Different religions generate admirable lives while making incompatible claims about a personal God, non-dual Brahman or emptiness. To infer a transcendent object solely from fruits commits a pragmatic substitution: usefulness replaces truth. Further, social approval of "good fruits" may reflect the evaluator's own moral norms.

A defender can offer a cumulative rather than deductive argument. Fruits may raise credibility when joined with coherent phenomenology, reliable character, disciplined preparation, absence of known defeaters and convergence of testimony. Swinburne's principle of credulity permits an initial presumption in favour of apparent experience; transformation may strengthen that presumption by making deception less likely. Alston's doxastic-practice model likewise includes override and discernment procedures. Yet neither move makes fruits independently sufficient.

An objection to the original proposition is that "authentication of the subject" may itself be too strong: impressive conduct can coexist with mistaken interpretation. The correction is to say that fruits support the authenticity and seriousness of the transformation, not the infallibility of the subject.

There is also a reverse caution: absence of spectacular virtue does not automatically falsify an experience. Moral development may be gradual, socially obstructed or uneven. Fruits should therefore be assessed longitudinally and proportionately, not used as an instant binary test. Their force lies in consilience with other evidence rather than in a single heroic act.

Therefore moral fruits have genuine but bounded epistemic value. They publicly corroborate sincerity, integration and practical depth; as one strand in a cumulative case, they may support *prima facie* warrant. They neither deductively verify the transcendent object nor resolve conflicts among religious interpretations.

Why this earns marks: Tests both halves of the statement; uses James and Indian discernment; distinguishes utility, authenticity and truth; offers a cumulative reply; gives a calibrated verdict.

ORIGINAL 4 - 15 marks

Question: Is mystical experience best understood through a common core or through irreducible religious diversity? Discuss with reference to Stace, Zaehner and constructivism.

Model solution: Neither an undifferentiated common core nor absolute diversity is adequate. Mystical reports display recurring phenomenological families, but their objects and logical structures are too different to be treated as one neutral experience with optional labels.

W. T. Stace offers the strongest common-core account. Extrovertive mysticism perceives unity through sensory multiplicity; introvertive mysticism excludes sensory and conceptual content, leaving unitary consciousness. Both display objectivity, blessedness, sacredness, paradox and ineffability. By separating experience from interpretation, Stace explains why Christian, Advaitic and Buddhist descriptions may diverge while sharing experiential depth.

The objection is that “interpretation” may be carrying all inconvenient differences. Identity with Brahman, communion with God and insight into emptiness do not merely attach different names to one relation: one abolishes subject-object duality, another preserves it, and a third may reject any substantial self or ultimate substance.

R. C. Zaehner therefore distinguishes nature, monistic and theistic mysticism. His classification protects the difference between oneness with nature, isolation or identity of soul, and loving union with a personal God. Its weakness is his confessional ranking of theistic mysticism as highest. The classification can be retained while the hierarchy is dropped.

Steven Katz radicalises diversity through constructivism: expectations, language and practices shape the experience itself, so there is no unmediated common event. This explains tradition-specific content but risks making experience merely self-confirming. Robert Forman’s Pure Consciousness Event challenges Katz at the contentless limit: if no content is present, what exactly is constructed? Katz may reply that preparation, recognition and memory remain mediated even if the episode is sparse.

A further complication is that “common core” can name more than one claim. It may mean identical phenomenal content, a shared formal structure, or merely recurrent transformative consequences. Evidence against identical content need not eliminate formal similarities such as unity or ineffability. Conversely, agreement about peaceful effects does not establish one metaphysical object. The debate becomes clearer when these levels are not conflated.

Advaita is therefore an especially useful test: its identity-claim may share formal unity with Stace’s core while resisting reduction to Zaehner’s theistic relation.

A defensible synthesis treats the evidence through **family resemblance**. Stace’s extrovertive/introvertive distinction and recurring marks identify cross-cultural patterns; Zaehner correctly preserves monistic/theistic difference; constructivism warns that reports cannot be stripped clean of formation. Mediation need not equal fabrication, but it blocks easy proof of a universal identical core.

Thus mystical experience is neither simply one nor wholly many. It consists of overlapping phenomenological families whose intentional objects and doctrinal structures may remain irreducibly different.

Why this earns marks: Reconstructs all three positions; avoids accepting Zaehner’s ranking; uses identity-versus-relation; includes Forman’s reply; reaches a discriminating synthesis.

ORIGINAL 5 - 20 marks

Question: Can religious experience provide *prima facie* justification for belief in a transcendent reality? Evaluate with reference to Swinburne, Alston and Indian claims of direct realisation.

Model solution: Religious experience can provide *prima facie*, defeasible justification for the experiencer, and weaker testimonial support for others, but it does not amount to public proof of a transcendent reality. The defensibility of this claim depends on parity with ordinary epistemic practices and on how seriously religious diversity functions as a defeater.

Richard Swinburne’s **principle of credulity** gives the initial argument. If it epistemically seems to a subject that X is present, then, other things being equal, probably X is present. We normally trust perception unless there are specific reasons for doubt; consistently applied, this presumption should not be withdrawn merely because the apparent object

is God. His related principle of testimony allows others some reason to trust sincere reports. The warrant remains defeasible by unreliability, conflicting evidence, background improbability or a superior explaining-away account.

William Alston develops a more practice-centred defence in *Perceiving God*. On his theory of appearing, perception is constituted by an object's seeming to present itself, not necessarily by sensory qualities. Some experiences of God can therefore be "M-perceptions" generating M-beliefs. Such beliefs arise within Christian Mystical Practice, a socially established doxastic practice with recognised inputs, outputs and override procedures. Sense perception, memory and induction cannot be non-circularly validated without using those very practices. Since demanding an external proof from religion alone would be asymmetrical, participation in an established mystical practice may be practically rational, and its outputs *prima facie* justified.

Alston's conclusion is deliberately modest. He does not prove that the practice is reliable or that every M-belief is justified all things considered. He shifts the burden to the sceptic to identify a relevant epistemic inferiority rather than merely citing circularity common to all practices.

Indian traditions supply both reinforcement and complication. Advaita calls *aparokṣānubhūti* immediate and self-certifying: Brahman is not perceived as external but recognised as self-luminous consciousness. *Śruti*, reason and *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* discipline the recognition; the guru and ethical transformation provide tests. Yoga and contemplative traditions also present repeatable training and predicted transformations, approximating expert perception. Yet these claims are not neutral observations. Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves communion with a personal Brahman; Buddhism may report emptiness without a creator; thus the "object" and structure differ.

Three objections are decisive. First, naturalistic accounts attribute experience to neural activity, suggestion, deprivation or wish-fulfilment. This can become a defeater when it demonstrates unreliability, but a neural mechanism alone does not explain away the object: ordinary perception is neurally mediated too. Causal mediation and truth-value are distinct.

Second, religious experiences lack the robust public cross-checking, prediction and agreement of sense perception. Alston replies that traditions do possess discernment and override systems, though they are weaker. This difference justifies a lower confidence level, not necessarily zero warrant.

Third, **diversity** is stronger than neurology. Mutually incompatible practices may each be established and internally coherent. Alston's suggestion that participants may rationally "sit tight" preserves practical rationality but does not resolve truth. Hick's culturally mediated responses to the Real offer one reconciliation, while constructivists contend that traditions shape the experiences themselves. A modest response claims family resemblance, not identical content; however, this weakens inference to any specific transcendent object.

The warrant must therefore be indexed. For the subject, a coherent experience arising within disciplined practice, producing fitting fruits and surviving known defeaters may rationally ground belief. For a hearer, testimony supplies some evidence but competes with plural testimony. For public reason, the episode can be assessed for authenticity and coherence, not converted into demonstration.

Thus religious experience can provide *prima facie* justification, especially personal and practice-relative justification. Swinburne explains the initial presumption; Alston explains rational practice; Indian traditions add non-sensory directness and disciplined replication. But diversity and limited cross-checking prevent the move from defeasible warrant to universally binding proof.

Why this earns marks: Defines the exact epistemic level; reconstructs Swinburne and Alston without overclaiming; supplies Indian parity; ranks naturalism, cross-checking and diversity objections; differentiates subject, testimony and public proof.

ORIGINAL 6 - 20 marks

Question: "Religious experience is always mediated, but mediation does not necessarily amount to fabrication." Critically evaluate.

Model solution: The statement is defensible if "mediation" means that concepts, practices, language, embodiment and expectations condition how an experience occurs and is recognised, while "fabrication" means that these conditions wholly produce an object with no independent constraint. Religious experience is probably never interpretation-free; it does not follow that it is therefore unreal.

Steven Katz gives the strongest mediation thesis. Against perennialism, he argues that there are no unmediated mystical experiences. A Jewish mystic formed by covenantal theism, an Advaitin trained in *neti neti*, and a Buddhist analysing non-self do not first undergo a neutral event and later attach different descriptions. Their disciplines and categories help structure what is salient and possible within the experience. This explains why reports display detailed doctrinal differences rather than merely different vocabulary.

The thesis gains force from the contrast between **intentional encounter** and **non-dual awareness**. Otto's subject confronts the numinous "wholly other"; theistic mysticism preserves a relation to a personal God; Advaita's *aparokṣānubhūti* sublates the subject-object distinction; Buddhism may deny both a permanent subject and substantial absolute. These are logically different structures. Zaehner's distinction among nature, monistic and theistic mysticism therefore preserves something that Stace's common-core account risks flattening.

Yet mediation does not entail fabrication. Ordinary perception is also shaped by concepts, attention and expert training while remaining answerable to objects. A radiologist sees patterns a novice misses; acquired categories improve access rather than inventing anatomy. Religious disciplines may similarly cultivate capacities and impose correction. Experiences also surprise, resist expectation and transform prior commitments, suggesting that subjects do not simply write the desired script.

William Alston's doxastic-practice account supplies an epistemic form of this reply. Beliefs emerge from socially established practices with inputs and override systems; no practice, including sense perception, is validated from a wholly external standpoint. Religious mediation can therefore be rational without being incorrigible. Indian methods such as *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*, yogic discipline and guru-guided discernment make explicit that preparation is intended to remove distortion, not manufacture an object.

Robert Forman challenges constructivism through the Pure Consciousness Event, a supposedly contentless state with nothing for concepts to shape. This objection is strongest against a total claim that every experiential feature is doctrinally constructed. Katz can still reply that entry, recognition, memory and interpretation remain mediated. Consequently, Forman may establish a minimally common experiential limit without proving a common metaphysical object.

Radhakrishnan moves further toward a perennial depth. In *The Hindu View of Life*, direct integral intuition of the spiritual Real precedes creeds, which are secondary formulations. This supports inter-religious openness, but risks treating theistic communion and Buddhist emptiness as imperfect expressions of an Advaitic unity. A more defensible version speaks of family resemblance or analogous transformation rather than identical content.

The strongest objection to the statement is sceptical: once there is no unmediated access, how can one distinguish disclosure from tradition-induced projection? Three criteria help without guaranteeing truth: experiential coherence and resistance to wish-fulfilment; public fruits and stable transformation; and communal override procedures capable of rejecting episodes. Cross-traditional convergence adds limited support, while persistent incompatible objects remains a defeater.

The opposite error is neuro-reduction. Showing neural or psychological mediation explains a mechanism, not necessarily away the object. A genuine perception and a hallucination both have neural causes; what matters is whether the causal process is appropriately connected to reality and survives defeaters.

Therefore mediation is unavoidable and philosophically informative: it qualifies claims of pure, universal experience and requires humility about interpretation. But fabrication is a further conclusion demanding evidence of systematic unreliability or unconstrained projection. The best verdict rejects both naïve immediacy and total constructivism: religious experience may be mediated disclosure, though its object receives only defeasible, tradition-situated warrant.

Why this earns marks: Defines the key terms; reconstructs Katz; compares Stace, Zaehner, Forman, Alston and Radhakrishnan; integrates Indian practice; distinguishes causal mechanism from epistemic defeat; finishes with a graded middle position.